The recovery of abducted persons and rehabilitation of widows proved to be another challenge. Tens of thousands of women were abducted during Partition, and after an inter-dominion treaty was signed, the Central Recovery Operation was launched, lasting nearly a decade.[28] Kamlaben Patel and Mridula Sarabhai (1911–74) played stellar roles in locating, repatriating and rehabilitating abducted women. In one of the more remarkable titles in Indian legal history, The Abducted Persons Recovery and Restoration Act was passed in 1949. Another issue related to women was widowhood, which was traditionally stigmatized in Indian society. The sheer scale of the phenomenon jolted the government into action by creating a separate women's section in the ministry of rehabilitation headed by Rameshwari Nehru (1886–1966), the founding member of the All India Women's Conference. The women's section provided care homes and hired the services of numerous charitable organizations, women's welfare groups and academic institutions engaged in social work such as the Tata Institute of Social Sciences.

While Punjab was the epicentre of mass migrations, there were migrations and incidents in other places too along the western frontier. Extreme violence against Muslims and displacements were observed in Hindu-dominated Alwar and Bharatpur of present-day Rajasthan as well as in Jammu, near Kashmir.[29] Many Muslims from present-day Maharashtra, Uttar Pradesh and other states migrated to West Punjab and Sindh. These Urdu-speaking migrants, called muhajirs, were influential members of the Muslim League and played an important role in defining Pakistani politics in the initial years. The situation of Hindus and other non-Muslims in Sindh, the other large province of Pakistan, was uncertain for quite some time but the influx of muhajirs and escalating levels of violence led to the evacuation of over half a million people by air, road and sea.[30] Hindus dominated four of the five major cities of Sindh—Hyderabad, Shikarpur, Larkana and Sukkur—and were almost as dominant as the Muslims in Karachi. This changed soon after Partition, though a much larger share of Hindus stayed back in Sindh than in West Punjab. A large number of the Sindhis who moved to India settled in present-day Maharashtra and Gujarat.